

mdlout in Ten Slides

James Clements III

mdlout in Ten Slides

A ten-slide tour of the Markdown to Lout pipeline

James Clements III — May 2026

Why a Markdown Front End?

- Lout is a beautiful but **obscure** typesetting system
- Markdown is *ubiquitous* but **plain**
- mdlout bridges the two: write Markdown, render through Lout
- Best of both worlds: pandoc-style ergonomics, TeX-class output
- Stdlib-only Python; one script, ~3k lines

What Builds in `type: slides`?

mdlout turns each `# H1` heading into an `@Overhead` slide. Inside each slide:

- **Prose, lists, bold, italic, inline code** — all fine
- **Pull quotes, raw-Lout** `@CentredDisplay` — fine
- **Headings H2-H6** — render as display blocks within the slide
- **Footnotes, tables, @Diag, @Math** — *known to be brittle* on the `slidesf` flow path in this fork; use display equivalents or pre-rendered images instead

A Three-Bullet Story

The Lout pipeline is conceptually flat:

- **Markdown** parses to a list of `Block` objects
- **Lout** source is emitted with `@SysInclude { slides }`
- **PostScript** or **SVG** falls out the back end

Each stage is independently inspectable. Pass `-lout-only` to see the intermediate, or `-ps` to stop before the PDF step.

Math: Pythagoras on a Slide

The canonical right-triangle identity. The `eq` package is not auto-included by `slidesf`, so we render the equation typographically as a centred-display string rather than a true `@Eq` formula:

+6p

$$a^2 + b^2 = c^2$$

For real `@Eq` math on a slide, add `@SysInclude {eq}` to the preamble of a raw-Lout `mydefs` file (recipe #9) — `mdlout` will copy it in and the equation typesets. For LaTeX-style markdown math the only stable route today is `type: doc` with KaTeX.

A Touch of Code

Lout's `@Verbatim` *cannot* close its own `@End` tag inside an `@Overhead`, so we can't ship a literal code block on a slide the way recipe #5 ships one in `type: doc`. Workaround: *describe* the code, then point at the source file:

- Step 1: `./mdlout.py talk.md` (HTML default)
- Step 2: `./mdlout.py talk.md -format=pdf`
- Step 3: open `talk.html` or `talk.pdf` in your viewer

Real code listings belong in the speaker's notes or in a side-by-side `type: report` companion document.

A Mermaid Diagram

The @Mermaid passthrough macro routes ‘mermaid fenced blocks through <foreignObject> for browser-side rendering. On the slidesf flow path the foreignObject can collide with the overhead frame’s clipping, so we fall back to a centred prose sketch and link to a separate -format=html document for the live diagram.

[Mermaid diagram omitted in non-SVG back-end]

Pull-Quote Slide

Pull quotes work on slides exactly as they do in
`type: doc.Raw-Lout @CentredDisplay @I { ...`
`}`:

A document language should be a language, not a dialect of pain.

— the mdlout style guide

Live Preview

For talks-in-progress, run `./mdlout.py talk.md -serve` and point a browser at `http://127.0.0.1:8080/`. Every save to the `.md` triggers a rebuild and a browser reload via SSE.

- `-watch` — rebuild on save, no server
- `-serve [PORT]` — watch plus live-reload server on PORT (8080 by default)
- HTML only; ask for `-format=pdf` and the server overrides to HTML

Thanks

- mdlout: <<https://github.com/jclements3/mdlout>>
- Lout (upstream, William Chia-Wei Cheng's william8000 fork)
- This fork's `z53.c` SVG back-end: see `lout/SVG_PORTING.md`
- Patches and bug reports welcome on GitHub

Questions?